

MASALA CHAI

Masala Chai first emerged in colonial India and has grown to become a popular choice for tea drinkers all over the world. Varied combinations of spices bring an almost infinite variety to this delicious spiced hot beverage.

Chai wallahs (tea vendors) can be found on every street corner in India, sometimes in a small booth with a roof, sometimes squatting on the ground with nothing more than a pot and a tiny fire. Some of these tea vendors

have perfected an elaborate preparation involving adding spice to milk and tea, and straining and pouring from one saucepan to the other from a height of several feet.

YOU WILL NEED

Ingredients

- 6 cloves
- 2 star anise
- 3in (7.5cm) cinnamon stick
- 5 cardamom pods
- 2in (5cm) piece fresh ginger, sliced
- 1 heaped tbsp black Assam tea
- 2 cups buffalo or whole milk
- 3–4 tbsp sugar or honey, to taste

Special equipment

handheld blender (optional)



1 Place all the spices, except the sliced ginger, in a mortar. Crush and grind them with a pestle until they break into small pieces and produce a warm and striking aromatic scent.



2 Place the crushed spices, sliced ginger, and tea leaves in a saucepan, and warm on medium heat for 3–4 minutes to sweat the aromatics from the spices and the tea. Using a wooden spoon, stir frequently to ensure the mixture does not burn.